

THE PARENTAL EDGE

Indian shooters' parents play a crucial role in their success, significantly contributing to their emotional and mental well-being.

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Manu Bhaker didn't show any emotion after shooting a disappointing 93 in her first series in the 10m air pistol event of the third Olympic selection trials. Neither did her coach, Jaspal Rana, who watched from the spectator gallery of the MP Shooting Academy in Bhopal, as she dropped to last place early in the contest.

Manu's mother, Sumedha Bhaker, couldn't deal with the stress, though. "*Mere se dekha nahi jayega* (I won't be able to see this)," she muttered as she rushed out of the range.

While waiting outside, she mouthed prayers and scribbled furiously into a notebook, only to return at the end of the qualification round, by which time Manu had come through in first place with 577 points.

Sumedha wasn't the only nervous parent in Bhopal. While she left the venue, unable to watch her daughter compete, the other parents tried their best to hide their nerves.

Sujit Sen, father of Tilottama Sen, says he hides behind walls so that she won't see him while shooting in the 10m air rifle event.

"I don't want her to turn around and see me. If I show any worry

on my face, it could end up disturbing her. So, I usually just stay 180 degrees behind her to avoid coming into her peripheral vision," he says.

These parents have gone out of their way to ensure that their children have the best possible system in place for the competition.

Pawandeep Singh Samra, father of Asian Games champion and world record holder Sift Kaur Samra, dropped her off in Bhopal after driving down 1200 kilometres from Faridkot in Punjab instead of taking a flight or train.

Not only did he want Sift to be able to travel easily from her hotel in Bhopal to the shooting range, he also wanted to avoid her going through the headache of travelling with firearms through the airport.

He wasn't the only one. Sachin Singh, father of Esha Singh, who will be competing in the 25m pistol event at the Paris Games, drove 850 kilometres from Hyderabad to Bhopal for the same reason.

Of course, not all parents are like this. It's mostly the parents of younger girls who feel they have to be there by their daughter's side.

"Boys don't seem to have the same kind of clingy parents. They seem to value their independence a



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